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CLASS STRUCTURE IN RURAL ORISSA

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After a tour in India in 1967, Thorner, the famous Indologist, found the emergence of capitalist farming in some parts of the country due to 'green revolution'. The distinct features identified in such farming were excessive use of hired labour, increased commodity production, and reinvestment of a substantial portion of agricultural surplus for increased agricultural production (Thorner, 1969 : 211-12). As such a change implies a radical change in agrarian relations, between man and man; some progressive economists have ventured to study the issue in greater detail. But the first significant research with rich quantitative material on the big farmers of Punjab concluded that the capitalist farming had not appeared in Indian agriculture (Rudra, 1970, 1974, 1975). These findings have provoked several others (Patnaik, 1971, 1973; Chattopadhyay, 1972; Ram, 1973). The study was attacked for being ahistorical, classifying farmers as capitalist and non-capitalist, instead of locating the trends in terms of capitalistic features. This important debate on the changing modes of production in Indian agriculture, specially the emergence and dominance of capitalist relations in agriculture and identification of vital indicators and processes for the characterisation of capitalist mode of production as distinct from a feudal or a semi-feudal, has inaugurated a new era in agrarian research. Some observed the dominance of semi-feudal relations in Indian agriculture (Bhaduri, 1973; Prasad, 1974; Sau, 1973); while still others argued to use a special concept such as a colonial mode of production to characterise Indian agriculture (Banaji, 1972; Alavi, 1975).

The debate on mode of production is neither barren nor can it be discarded as some thought it to be (Saith and Tankha, 1972; Cleaver, 1976), rather it is crucially connected with the question of who is the main enemy, and how to mobilize the rural masses for the whole programme, it is nothing less than a *must* in formulating their emancipation. Though by itself, it is inadequate to chart out the initial propositions of the programme for agrarian development.

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It is true that the actual societies are much more complex than any given mode of production. The production relations do not in their totality conform to a single type with a homogeneous structure. For instance, there is not a single illustration in human history, where the whole working population was enslaved. Instead, in every slave society, there were survivals of primitive communism, the rising traces of feudalism, existence of independent petty-producers, and also in many cases, an emerging merchant class. Likewise, there is no perfect example of feudal system. Capitalism and socialism too have never existed in their full pristine purity; reality is always an admixture of more than one mode of production.

It follows then that in almost every society, besides a predominant mode of production, there exists one or more modes. Marx rightly said that over the same economic basis, there may be endless variations and gradations "due to innumerable empirical circumstances, natural environment, racial composition, effects of external historical influences, etc... and can be ascertained only by the analysis of the empirically given -conditions" (1971:791-92). The multistructural social systems, where each structure constitutes a distinctive type of production relations with its specific laws of development, provide complex forms with greater class diversity. The mechanism of dialectical interaction between different structures is thus very complicated and is beyond the comprehension of any mechanical scheme. In their own right, they demand a detailed analysis to understand the prevalent trends of society, the motive forces of transformations, and the relationship between the base and superstructure.

The issue of social formation puts certain limits on the significance of the debate on modes of production. Nevertheless, since the understanding of the dominant mode of production is decisive to understand the dynamics of any society, its importance cannot be belittled. The debate has also laid bare the basic characters of different modes of production, albeit at a theoretical level, which would help us in understanding the actual given contexts.

From the various formulations, we note only the salient features, rather ideal indicators, of feudalism, semi-feudalism, and capitalism. *Feudalism in agriculture* means that the surplus is appropriated primarily in the form of rent, and that the direct producers are bound

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by particularistic ties of dependence to those who control the land. The surplus accumulated through rent and usury is not invested for agricultural development but rather used (or abused) in conspicuous consumption and personal control. *Semi-feudal agriculture* is characterised by an extensive non-legalised sharecropping system, perpetual indebtedness of the small tenants, concentration of usury and land control in the hands of the *same* economic class and lack of accessibility for the small tenants to rural markets while they are forcibly involved in involuntary exchanges. The transitional mode is inimical to capital investment in agriculture. By contrast, *capitalism in agriculture* is marked by a shift to wage labour, who are generally free of bonds of dependence to particular landholders. The surplus, appropriated primarily in the form of surplus-value, is used to a significant degree for reinvestment in agriculture. Besides, there is the increasing concentration of the means of production and thereby, a development of the new productive forces.

What is needed is to take these ideal characters and the debate at large to different empirical situations in different regions of this vast country so as to arrive at a much more meaningful understanding of Indian agrarian structure, and its potentialities and directions for change. In this context, the knowledge and experience of sociology and social anthropology, specially the field research, appear to be quite useful.

But the preoccupation of sociologists and social anthropologists in India, with caste, so far did not allow them to participate in the debate through rich field experience. Not only the analyses of class and class relations in rural India have been neglected but also the Indian reality was often, presented as distinct from class society. It is also a common belief that caste is the context within which the subsequent observations on economics and politics acquire their meaning. The structuralist-functionalist approach analysing the structure of appearance has been stressing on patron-client relationship in Indian society. The terms of reference for research never came to terms with the deeper social structure. As a result understanding of class relations became more concealed. The extremely limited exercises on classes in Indian villages too have depended on census and survey material on attributional data. Those are of limited significance to provide the basis for understanding the relations of production and the inherent

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contradictions between the forces and relations of production. It is however, refreshing that recently some work has been done in response to the debate, by a few students of sociology.

This paper makes a modest attempt to analyse the classes and class relations in three villages of Orissa and to consider the particular modes of production operative in them. The study covers a predominantly tribal village, a village characterised primarily by feudal relationship, and a village manifestly showing signs of capitalistic development in agriculture. However, these villages are tribal, feudal, and capitalist in the predominant sense and not in the pure sense.

The selection of the units has an in-built rationale at the substantive level in the macro-context of Orissa. Of all the States of the Indian Union, the State of Orissa contains the highest percentage of population (23.11) under the category of Scheduled Tribes. The extent of the Scheduled Area covers as much as one-third of the territory of the State. And depending upon the above two attributes 34 out of 147 seats have been reserved for the Scheduled Tribes in the Legislative Assembly (23.13%). Together, they provide a special significance in the selection of tribal village belonging to a tribal constituency. Following from this a village, Pokalingia by name, was selected from G. Udaigiri constituency of Phulbani district (hereafter V-P).

The second village was selected from an ex-zamindari area. Mention may be made that at the time of Independence, as much as 81 percent of the privately owned land was under zamindari system. Besides, various surveys repeatedly underlined that Orissa has remained an area of backwardness and deprivation, containing more than 70 percent of the rural population below the poverty line in 1972-73. Only 16 percent of the area of the State is irrigated as against 75 percent in Punjab and 25 percent in the country as a whole. Similarly; compared to the 95 kgs. of fertiliser consumed per hectare in Punjab only 9 kgs. are applied per hectare in Orissa. As a result, in spite of substantial increase in area, the total agricultural output has actually recorded a decline in 10 districts out of the 13, "because of a big fall in productivity." In foodgrains, the productivity has rapidly declined from 935 kgs. per hectare to 487 kgs during 1962-65 and 1970-73, when States like Punjab have increased its production from 1095 kgs. to 1959 kgs. (Bhalla and Alagh, 1979: 42-45, 57). This

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denotes continued reliance on the existing low productivity techniques and misuse of land resources, a feature common to pre-capitalist agriculture. In addition, the highly skewed landownership, 3 percent controlling 25 percent of land while 60 percent own as little as 10 percent of the land-widespread tenancy (32%), staggering under-employment of labour force (28%), negligible expansion of industrial employment, debtor-creditor nexus – 90% of the rural credit from money-lenders, speculative trade, and conspicuous wastage of surplus by the landed gentry denote the domination of unproductive feudal agriculture in Orissa economy. Thus the selection of the second village is justified. The village by name, Talapatna (hereafter V–T), of Dharakate Panchayat in Ganjam district, is marked by the concentration of land in a few hands and distribution of uneconomical parcels of land among a small section of agricultural population.

The third village, Mukundapur (hereafter V-M), was selected from the ex-ryotwari area near a small industrial township. It may be recalled that ryotwari system was initially characterised by peasant proprietorship and was enforced in a small part of Orissa. But since it has been widely presumed that this system was more progressive than the other tenures, it may be useful to compare the present situation with that of non-ryotwari regions. Moreover, as the V–M is situated near the industrial township of Aska, it may be possible to locate the influence of industry on agrarian relations. Considering the limits of industrial growth, irrigation and cash crop cultivation in Orissa, this village may not be the representative of Orissa agriculture. Nevertheless, it may have some similarities with a section of villages in the coastal belt of Orissa and may contribute to the understanding of the penetration of capitalistic mode of production in agriculture in the state.

This is not to imply that the three villages are representatives of their respective universes; or of the total universe. That would require a scale of research clearly beyond the scope of the present exercise. Yet, the assumption behind the selection of these villages is that they would reveal some of the realities of their respective universe, and therefore would prove useful as a basis for preliminary study; particularly when, unlike many other States, Orissa is not endowed with macro-level information on caste, class and power distribution, let alone their intersections. Still, however, the paper acknowledges

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two major weaknesses in the selection of the villages, namely (i) enough consideration was not given either to the spatial distribution of the villages or to the variations between the villages belonging to the selected area; and (ii) although there were 24 feudatory states in Orissa before Independence, none of the villages belonged to that region.

Population and Land Control :

V–P has 284 persons distributed in 68 households. The Kandha belonging to Scheduled Tribe category consists of a total of 210 persons in 50 households. The rest comprise of the non-tribal households. Excluding the Kamar and the Pana, the other castes were settled only in the last 25 to 40 years, by single households and not as caste groups. In contrast to gradual growth of this village, the V-T came into existence some 80 years ago, founded by the zamindar of Dharakote. The settlers worked as tenants and artisans of the zamindar. After zamindari abolition, several artisans and upper caste households, who had no land or had very meagre land, left the village during the mid-1950s. Today, it has 320 persons in 72 households; out of which the Khadal – a lower caste – alone constitute three-fourths of the total strengh. In V-M, the Alia, a backward caste, numerically dominates the population. They are distributed in 87 households with a population of 390. The Brahmin, Gauda, Keota, Dhoba, Bauri, Dandasi and Muslim constitute the rest 224 persons in 54 households. (Table-1). Each

TABLE 1

DISTRIBUTION OF HOUSEHOLDS AND POPULATION IN THE VILLAGES

Caste/Community	V-P	V-T	V-M
I *Upper Castes*			
Brahmin	—	—	5(19)
Kshatriya	—	2(13)	—
II *Backward Castes*			
Tanti	—	3(10)	—
Gauda	3(11)	5(22)	15(77)

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(Table 1 Contnd.)

Caste/Community	V-P	V-T	V-M
Gudia	—	1(5)	—
Teli	1(5)	—	—
Adia/Odiya	—	5(25)	87(390)
Kamar	1(4)	—	—
Sundi	1(3)	—	—
Keota	—	1(2)	7(22)
III *Scheduled Castes*			
Dhoba	—	3(12)	17(58)
Pana	11(45)	—	—
Khadal	—	52(231)	—
Bauri	—	—	4(13)
Hadi	1(6)	—	—
Dandasi	—	—	9(29)
IV *Other Communities*			
Muslim	—	—	1(6)
Kandha	50(210)	—	—
Total	68(284)	72(320)	145(614)

village manifests a disproportionately higher numerical position of one or other caste. Although a broad stratification on the basis of caste hierarchy is evident in all the villages, some difficulties arise in arriving at an acceptable classification in the hierarchical order.

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In V-P, there is both communal and private ownership of land. The former, however, is too little, standing at an average of 0.5 acres of shifting land, annually distributed among the tribal households. For our purpose, we would exclude the little communal land (29 acres) and consider only lands in individual possession. The distribution of private land is unequal. Only 7.3 per cent of the village land (out of 118 acres) is distributed among the two-thirds of the households. The Muthahead — an ex-administrative head of several villages — owns 20 acres of land outside the village whereas, four non-tribals from the nearby town together own 18 acres of V-P land[1].

The total cultivated area in V-T is 148 acres. In 1974 the village had an average of 2 acres of cultivated land per household. But ownership was highly concentrated. Only 17 families (23.6%) have their own land, totalling 56 acres. The remaining 92 acres are distributed between the zamindar (63 acres), his ex-manager (Diwan) residing 25 miles away (25 acres), and a small merchant of a nearby village (4 acres). The zamindar had about 735 acres of land in 18 villages, out of which, to avoid the land ceiling, he transferred 300 acres to a temple, which he had constructed in 1966[2]. The Diwan has 40 acres of land, including the land in V-T. Excluding the land owned by the three outside landowners in other villages, it is noticed that only 7.4 per cent of the village land is left for 90.6 per cent of the households. (Table-2). At the same time, almost half of the unsurveyed land of the village remains waste under the categories of pasture, mango groves, cremation ground etc. Excluding 10 acres belonging to the zamindar, the rest of the village land depends on the monsoon for cultivation. More than 90 per cent of the land is used for paddy cultivation, but the yield per acre is very small ranging between 300 to 400 kgs. after making deductions for the seed.[3]

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TABLE 2

PERCENTAGE DISTRIBUTION OF LAND IN THE THREE VILLAGES

Land Category (in acres)	V-P		V-T		V-M	
	Households	Land	Households	Land	Households	Land
Landless	31.9	—	73.3	—	28.4	—
Upto ½	31.9	5.6	5.3	1.0	25.6	9.7
½ - 1	2.8	1.7	8.0	3.0	20.3	14.5
1 - 2	—	—	2.7	1.7	12.8	19.4
2 - 3	13.9	21.9	1.3	1.7	6.9	15.9
3 - 5	12.5	32.7	4.0	7.4	2.7	10.9
5 - 10	4.2	18.6	1.3	5.4	2.0	11.6
10 - 20	2.8	19.5	—	—	1.3	18.0
20 - 30	—	—	2.7	37.2	—	—
above 30	—	—	1.3	42.6	—	—
Total	100.00 (N=72)	100.00 (N=118)	100.00 (N=75)	100.00 (N=148)	100.00 (N=148)	100.00 (N=155)

Note : In V-P four outside landowners and in V-T and V-M three outside landowners each, are included.

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In V-M, about 85 per cent of the working population depends on agriculture. The villages has a total of 155 acres of land of which more than 10 acres belong to three outside landowners while only 2 persons of this village have 2 acres of land in other villages. As many as 28.4 per cent of the households are landless and another 45.9 per cent of the households have upto one acre holding; whereas only 6 per cent of the households control 40.5 per cent of the total land. This means, in spite of one-fourth of the land being irrigated, sugarcane cultivation taking up, supplementary income from industry during the sugarcane crushing season available, still nearly half of the households possess uneconomic holding (upto 1 acre). In the last five years, only 7 households have sold 4.5 acres of land to four persons. Such a persistance of small holdings has naturally discouraged smooth development of the new forces of production (Marx, 197 : 787).

Classes and Class Relations

The classes are here defined by the relations in which the various sections stand to the means of production, by the manner in which the surplus is expropriated from the actual toilers, and by the way the expropriators spend it on. The various peasant classes are also identified according to the well-established definitions (Mao, 1965: 13-21, 23-59, 137-143).

(i) *Landlord*

He is the one who does not physically participate in major agricultural operations, but gets his land cultivated either by leasing them out (feudal type) or by employing wage labour, while he and his family confine themselves to supervision or to secondary labour (capitalist type).

Among the inhabitants of V-P, there is no landlord. But there are five outside landlords who operate in the village. Four merchants of the nearby town have 18 acres of land in the village, given to four sharecroppers of V-P and to one from outside the village. The share is equal. For sometime, one of the landlords has been harvesting two crops, and the cost of fertilizer is equally shared by the owner and the sharecropper. Three of the sharecroppers are

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indebted to their own landlords. One Kandha sharecropper is cultivating the land of 40 acres belonging to Kandha landlord of a nearby village. To cultivate a portion of that land, the V-P sharecropper lives in that village.

In contrast, V-T has three landlords who control 62.2 percent of the total village land. The zamindar's 63 acres in V-T cultivated by 17 sharecroppers. Though in a very broad sense leasing in appears as a hereditary right; in practice, the tenants can be evicted any time according to the whim of the zamindar. The threat of eviction keeps the tenants loyal to the landowners on all issues. The tenants are responsible for maintaining the land, have to pay for seed, local manure and the cost of threshing and hulling the paddy. But for large scale operations, the zamindar provides the inputs, though the total labour is entirely that of the tenants. He also provides half of the cost of the chemical fertiliser. Normally he is not in favour of using much fertiliser nor is he interested in new varieties of seeds. The tenants receive a share of two units while the zamindar claims three units for paddy. But for crops like ragi, redgram, mustard, til, gingelly the share is 1:1. The tenants have also several unpaid labour obligations like supply of wood for use as fuel, rethatching the cattle sheds, grazing and bathing cattle and many others (Pathy, 1975: 893-900). The zamindar deals with the tenants through the Diwan, of whom not only the tenants but also farm labourers are afraid. Next to him is the chief sharecropper, a trusted person in the house of the zamindar, who has the maximum amount of leased-in land as a single tenant. Usually the tenants convey their grievances to the zamindar through him.

The people of V-T call the zamindar father (Bapa). His paternalism finds expression in the festival for the village deity, in occasionally giving food or clothing to the villagers or in resolution of petty dispute within and outside the village and so on. Fourteen of the 17 tenants are indebted to the zamindar, mostly paddy loans. In 1959, the second brother from the family became the sarpanch, having been unanimously elected. In 1962, he was the chairman of Dharakote panchayat samiti. In 1967 and 1971 he was elected to the legislative assembly, and was twice deputy minister. However, in 1974 elections he was defeated by a Congress candidate; and his wife was also defeated in 1979.

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The other two landlords belonging to upper and backward castes have largely similar relations with their tenants, but do not have much importance in the V-T politics. One of them has leased-out his 25 acres to seven tenants. He frequently evicts tenants. Unlike the zamindar, he shares the cost of local manure. Unpaid labour is much restricted by tradition, physical distance, and frequent evictions. The other small landowner has given a part of his land for fixed rent in cash (Guffa) and the rest on fixed rent in kind (Dhulia Sanja) to two tenants in all. The tenants rarely render him personal services.

In V-M, there are 12 landlords, out of whom 7 are outsiders (Table-3). Four outside landlords do not have land in V-M but seven tenants of V-M cultivate their land. Five tenants cultivate the lands of the other three outside landlords. One of the tenents has leased it on fixed rent basis, while the others follow the common pattern of rent of 1:1 share for dry land and 2:3 for irrigated land. For sugarcane, the share is 1:3 without seed or manure, and 1:1 with all the necessary inputs. Five people of V-M are indebted to outside landlords, none of whom have any significance in V-M politics. The inside landlords owning land between 5 to 15 acres belong to upper and backward castes. The most powerful among them frequently evicts his tenants and participates in usurious money-lending.[4] He is also a building contractor, and hires out his pump set and two iron ploughs to the peasants. He is simultaneously rentier, usurer and trader of the main cash crop. He gets fertilizer, seeds and other inputs on subsidized rates from the cooperatives and the sugar factory. From him, several peasants borrow the inputs on credit, which they pay back mainly with produce. The second landlord has five tenants. Three of them have taken land on fixed rent basis. Six persons are indebted to him. Like the first landlord, he too gets subsidized inputs and is also a dealer in fertiliser. He is the leader of a faction, which was once decisive in the V-M politics. The other landlords have engaged five tenants, and eight persons are indebted to them.

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TABLE 3

CLASS DISTRIBUTION IN THE THREE VILLAGES

Class	V-P		V-T		V-M	
	Households	%	Households	%	Households	%
Landlord	5	6.8	3	4.0	12	7.9
Rich peasant	4	5.5	2	2.7	5	3.3
Middle peasant	14	19.2	5	6.7	14	9.2
Poor peasant	27	37.0	10	13.3	79	52.0
Pure sharecropper	—	—	22	29.3	—	—
Farm, Forest, Mine labourer	14	19.2	28	37.3	21	13.8
Industrial Labourer	—	—	—	—	11	7.2
Business	5	6.8	2	2.7	3	2.0
Others	4	5.5	3	4.0	7	4.6
Total	73	100.00	75	100.00	152	100.00

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In all the villages, the landlords are not only rentiers and usurers, but are also traders. This is carried out through the debt repaid by the tenants at harvest time in staples and cash crops, and their own surplus, which is sold chiefly when the market prices go up considerably. Actually, after paying a portion of the debt, the remaining harvest is inadequate to meet the tenants' minimum subsistence. In the lean months, most of the landlords provide paddy at the then prevailing market price and collect it back at the harvest value of the crop. In V-M, a special feature is also added, where the landlords get subsidized inputs to be repaid in sugarcane, which they collect from the tenants and small peasants against their debt of the inputs taken from them. Obviously, high rate of interest is thus charged, keeping the tenants in perpetual indebtedness. Thus they are prevented from entering into the product market, and are forced to participate in the exchange market, obliging the landed class with a high profit. In V-M, it is pronounced with respect to sugarcane producing tenants, whilst in V-T, is is widely marked in staple production, and in V-P, is is of course, nearly insignificant being only loosely related to cultivation turmeric.

(ii) *Rich peasants*

A rich peasant is one who has independent holding and works in fields with the help of wage labour, although sometimes he may lease-out a portion of his holdings. His income derived from cultivation is sufficient to leave a regular surplus.

In V-P there are four rich peasants, holding between 8 and 12 acres. They belong to both tribal and backward caste categories. In case of the tribals, landownership and tradition reinforce each other to give leadership in the two factions of the village. The other two rich peasants are not involved in village politics. The *muthahead* cultivates his field with the help of agricultural labourers and also engages a semi-bonded labourer. He is also creditor of food grains to four persons. The village headmen, the other tribal rich peasant, is a moneylender of the village. He is also a trader in staples, and is the leader of the second major faction in the village. Two important points need to be stressed here. First, the myth of tribal homogenity does not hold true; there is a sharp development of internal differentiation within the community in relation to economy and politics. Secondly the noton that the non-tribal as a whole is the only exploting group of people is untenable.

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In V-T, there are two rich peasants. One cultivates his 30 acres of land with the help of farm servants as well as tenants. He leads the second biggest faction of the village and is allied to the Congress (I). Two acres of his personally cultivated land are cultivated by his tenants unpaid labour. (Bethi Uthana). Almost every year, he replaces one or two of his tenants and also changes field from one to another. He has two domestic servants; one of them works to repay his earlier debts. It is observed that though his economic position does not allow him to follow the life style of the zamindar — his political rival — he tries to act like him. The second rich peasant of backward caste origin cultivates his eight acres of land by wage labour and a few tenants who have fewer obligations to him.

In case of V-M, there are five rich peasants, belonging to upper and backward castes. Fifteen households are indebted to them. One of them is a ward member and another a caste-headman. Their dominance on the whole is very little in comparison to the landlords'. Excluding one, all are the supporters of the faction led by the second biggest landlord of the village.

Rich peasants seem to be more powerful in V-P followed by V-T, but in V-M, their dominance is relatively less. The village political power is shared by the rival rich peasants belonging to the same tribal group in V-P, by the main landlord and main rich peasant in V-T, and by two landlords of the same backward caste in V-M.

(iii) *Middle peasant*

A middle peasant is one whose family labour predominates over wage labour in his field. In a normal year, his income is sufficient to give him an independent living in the village.

There are 10 tribal and 4 non-tribal households in V-P, who may be considered as middle peasants. For most of them, the harvest is just sufficient for family sustenance. Those who have little surplus have smaller households. Two tribals of this class are strong supporters of the *Muthahead* faction. There is the pana-caste-headman of the village in this category who is also considered important on village matters at large.

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In V-T, only five belong to this class. The richest among them, belonging to the Scheduled Caste, is an active member of the CPI (Marxist) and organised four local movements concerning the interests of the tenants and labourers. All other middle peasants supplement their income by leasing-in land; and all of them are relatively conscious politically.

In V-M, there are 14 middle peasants distributed over five castes of the village. Two of them are Panchayat ward members. One of them is a peasant activist who normally works a lot in mobilizing the people against the landed interests.

From this, it appears that the power of middle peasants rest largely in their organizing capacity on class lines, and not derived from factional disputes; also this class is more capable of carrying the interests of the masses due to their independent living.

(iv) *Small Peasants*

The land he owns is too little for subsistence. Hence he does either sharecropping or farm labour in addition to cultivation of his own land.

So far as the small peasants are concerned, there are 22 tribal and 5 non-tribal households in V-P. Five of them supplement their income by sharecropping; fourteen have forest, farm and road labour as secondary occupation; and sixteen of them are indebted. As a whole, they play only a minor role in village politics. In V-T, there are 10 households with small holdings, eight of whom are also tenants. Their role in the village politics is diverse, and is of some significance only in relation to the three leaders. In V-M more than half of the households are small peasants, a historical product of the ryotwari land system. Twenty-seven of them are tenants, and 35 are indebted. Roughly, they are aligned with the two major factions of the village.

(v) *Labourers*

A farm worker is one whose living is derived solely from selling his labour power in agriculture and other allied activities.

The normal wage rate for male and female workers is Rs. 2.50 and 1.75 respectively, for roughly 10 hours of work per day. The

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wage rate shows considerable variations from village to village and also from season to seasons. In V-P, there are 13 households who engage in labour as their major source of living. Eighteen agricultural labourers out of 27, of V-T are indebted. The rate of interest is roughly 60 per cent till the next harvest. Most of loans are used for food and ceremonies, while only a small portion is used for productive purposes (11.2%). In V-M, there are 21 agricultural and 11 industrial workers, out of whom 21 are indebted. They are conscious, and have participated in a number of demonstrations organised by the CPI so far.

The Findings

To recapitulate the brief description, it may be mentioned that though the classical feudal relations of the western variety are not noticed even in V-T, none of the villages has shown definite signs of capitalist development. In V-P, turmeric and other cash crop cultivation is limited due to the predominance of subsistence economy and the inability of the local rich to participate in commerce. In V-T, the local rich, indulging in lending and controlling the internal market, consolidates the semi-feudal mode of production. In V-M, although chances of capitalistic development in agriculture are bright the landlords' and the rich peasants' involvement in rack-renting, usury, speculative trade, including control of inputs stand critically in the way.

In V-T, the primordial forms of slavery, intensive sharecropping and frequent evictions, continued indebtedness of the tenants and peasants for consumption loans, predominance of exchange economy, seasonal farm labour and poor development of commodity production and of the productive forces, confirm its semi-feudal character and demonstrate that as it is the development of agriculture is limited due to the formidable obstacles by the relations of production. In case of V-P, there seems to be a combined hold of a limited semi-feudal, merchant capital and communal mode. Recently, the merchant capital is compelled to come to terms with the tribal rich peasants and landlords, who have taken to usury and staple trade within the village. That is to say, the restricted trade has failed to become a favourable factor in the disintegration of the class structure, rather it has tended to reinforce it. The primary contradiction is between the peasant and the feudal landlords and

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rich peasants. Still complex is the case of V-M. There are only signs for capitalist development in terms of increased use of inputs, of cash crop cultivation, of investments in agriculture, and of emerging a relatively 'free' labour. But there is no trend. What prevails is the widespread tenancy, usury, exchange market, strong primordial attachments, persistence of small and unprofitable holdings, and the other features of semi-feudal agriculture. In other words, at present, the semi-feudal mode is dominant in a much different way than the V-T, and has allowed emergence of capitalist featnres. Further progress in that direction, however, seems to be limited without a change in relations of production. The three village situations studied in isolation from their relations with the State and the outside forces operating within the State, is obviously inadequate to characterise the mode of production in Orissa. The findings, of course, do indicate Orissa with a wider perspective and for a comprehensive analysis of the social reality and its potentialities for change.

Secondly, since often same class position is occupied by members of all castes, the caste status is not congruent with class status; although lower castes are naturally more located among the categories of small peasants, sharecroppers and labourers, and the higher caste groups are more concentrated in the landlord and rich peasant categories. Hence, the categories of caste and class are only broadly interwined and appear mutually to buttress each other. It has been correctly observed: "Every caste, sub-caste and religious community contributed its own share (in differential degrees) both to the baurgeois-landlord as well as to the proletarian-semiproletarian peasant classes. Class society was thus emerging within the very framework of an essentially caste society" (Namboodiripad, 1977: 18). But, in the pre-capitalist context of Orissa, it is often difficult to dissimilate infra – and superstructures, precisely as the economic classes do not come to full ideological and political articulation (Godelier, 1977:123). At present, the feudal interests use caste idiom for mobilising the various classes for their own sectional ends. Caste is used as "an ideological screen which hide social reality by scattering social divisions along the whole length of a formal hierarchy and submerging exploitative relations among them" (Meillassoux, 1973 : 108). Thus, caste consciousness and practices continue because class practices have not yet become dominant at political level. The economically constituted class (class in itself) does not

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lead automatically to the self conscious class (class for itself). Marx, therefore, repeatedly stressed that "the separate individuals form a class only in so far as they have to carry on a common battle against another class; otherwise they are on hostile terms with each other as competitors" (1964: 132).

NOTES

1. In Orissa, for preventing transfer of land of tribal to non-tribals, "The Orissa Scheduled Areas Transfer of Immovable Property Regulations" were passed in 1956, but were enforced only in 1959. Hence, the moneylenders, merchants and other non-tribals have utilised the interim period for their own advantage (Govt. of India, 1960-61 : 416).

2. Mention may be made that not only the ceiling laws had a very leisurely journey through the State legislature, giving ample time to the landlords to take all steps to nullify their effects as and when they could be imposed but also the first legislation — the Land Reform Act, 1960 — was introduced by a government in coalition with the Swatantra party, which was supposedly a reactionary feudal party. Of course, the subsequent ministeries upto 1973 have amended the Act thrice before legally enforcing it; still now, after giving numerous exemptions on orchards, land held by religious and educational institutions etc., the government has only estimated less than one per cent of cultivable area (1.71 lakh acres) as surplus and is yet to acquire that for redistribution. Meanwhile, the landlords have circumvented with ease the ceiling laws by malafide transfers to relatives, constructing temples and so on. The ambivalent policy bespeaks the anxiety of the State to preserve the parasitic semi-feudal classes.

3. In fact, in the State, while the paddy crop covers three-fourths of the total cropped area, its average yield stands at 9.6 quintals per hectare, the lowest among the major rice growing States of India (Patnaik, 1975 : 202).

4. Although there are a number of tenancy legislations in Orissa namely, the Orissa Tenants Protection Act, 1948; the Tenant Relief Act, 1955; the Land Reform Act, 1960 and its subsequent amendments in 1965, 1972, and 1974 - hardly they seem to have influenced the tenancy in the three villages. Sharecropping is widespread, evictions frequent, rent is as high as four times the legally fixed and one-eighth of the gross produce, and various forms of servitude are not uncommon. Thus the tenancy laws are virtually made infructuous.

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